

LET'S DE-JARGON INVESTING

We are too fond of our gold, real estate and FDs. Let's understand the true nature of each of these investments and what purpose they serve in our money box.

There was a time a few years back when my (then) teenager was sick of me. Nothing new in the history of teenage issues with parents, but she had (still has) a unique problem. It is not the usual teenage 'how-dumb-can-you-be' gripe or the 'will-you-just-get-off-my-case' grunt, or even 'how-did-you-get-so-far-with-so-little-brain' eye-roll. No. It's a totally new one that will put books on managing teenagers off track.

She's fed up of me 'talking money' wherever I go. Any amount of telling her that I do not initiate such conversations cuts no ice. Things got dangerous when the hair-cutting lady began discussing her financial life. While my daughter made retching, gagging noises, I tried to hear what the lady with the scissors said over the whine of the hairdryer. I learnt my lesson from Calvin (brother to Hobbes), who advises that it is always good to be nice to the person who holds something sharp near your neck. So I chose to answer hairdresser questions and dealt with the mutant teenager later.

The hair-cutting lady's worries were about not doing anything much with her money – the nagging feeling that she was standing still while everybody else was zipping past on fantastic money moves. She ended with a statement that I